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The Transition from Harpsichord to Piano^{*}

CONSIDERABLE literature has been devoted to the transition period during which the harpsichord was replaced by the piano.¹ Much material on this transition has been unearthed, in recent years particularly by the studies of Harding² and Parrish.³ We know that the piano, after a time of experimenting, acquired its first firm hold somewhere around 1750–60, and that by approximately 1800 the older keyboard instrument had practically disappeared.

Numerous questions, however, remain unanswered—questions which in our time of reviving old instruments are of importance for the actual rendition of keyboard music of that period. Should Mozart's violin and keyboard sonatas be performed with harpsichord? Which keyboard instrument is appropriate for an authentic performance of the continuo in the *secco* recitatives of Mozart's *Don Giovanni*, and Haydn's *The Creation*?

Before such special questions can be answered one has first to deal in detail with the more basic problems, among them that of how long, at a certain locality, the harpsichord actually stayed in use. The modest aim of this paper is to assemble a few details which, in connection with data known already, may help to throw light on the transition. We shall examine, by means of studying a representative number of titles of printed English keyboard music between *c.* 1750 and 1800, whether the wording of these titles (*for the harpsichord*; *for the harpsichord or pianoforte*; *for the pianoforte*) reveals anything in regard to the use of the two instruments. A comparison will then be made with respect to the transition as it took place in Paris. However, the approach by means of the terminology of sheet music titles seems impractical for France, because of difficulties in assembling a large enough group of such titles for a statistical examination. French music publishing seems to have been less advanced under the *Ancien Régime* than its British counterpart. During the last decade of the eighteenth century in particular, a period during which the number of English editions reached a climax, the

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turmoil of the French Revolution must have considerably handicapped French publishers whose richest clientèle had been decimated. It is also considerably more difficult to estimate the year of publication for French publications than for British ones.

Fortunately there exists an inventory of instruments confiscated during the Revolution which will permit us some insight⁴ in regard to the proportion of the two keyboard instruments in the possession of members of French society at that time. Their dates will reveal a few data concerning the introduction of the piano in France.

I

During the seventeenth century, the harpsichord had become the central instrument of musical performance. As the most important continuo instrument, it ruled the performance of both vocal and instrumental ensemble music. As a solo instrument, its metallic tone provided a transparency which lent itself to polyphony, and a brilliance which suited the baroque desire for elaborate embellishment. The harpsichord's organization, by means of stops and of a double keyboard, made it perfectly suited to the 'terrace dynamics' of the era.

In spite of all these qualities, criticism of the harpsichord was expressed, and, as time went on, we find such criticism more and more frequently. Often it appeared in the form of comparisons with the clavichord and, later, with the piano. More and more, as the eighteenth century progressed, musical expression required subtle shadings and *messe di voce* which the rigid crow quills of the harpsichord, operated through an equally rigid key mechanism, could not produce.

Cristofori's hammer-operated invention in 1709, the *gravicembalo con pian e forte*, originally encountered considerable opposition due to

"... the want of knowledge how, at first, to play it, because it is not sufficient to know how to play perfectly upon instruments with the ordinary keyboard; being a new instrument, it requires a person who understanding its capabilities shall have made a particular study of its effects"⁵

It took some time for harpsichordists to acquire the pianistic touch. Around the middle of the century, writers on music accepted the piano more readily. Bach, also originally sceptical, seems to have shown a more favourable attitude towards the piano in his late years.⁶ Quantz praises it considerably.⁷ In 1753, C. P. E. Bach mentions the 'Fortepiano' as having many advantages, *if it is sturdy and well built*.⁸ He also remarks that the harpsichord would be preferable for *gar zu starck besetzte Music*. In the second part of the *Versuch* (1762), he still has to

admit that 'certain singers' prefer the harpsichord or even the clavichord to the piano for accompaniment.⁹

Piano manufacturing had shifted from Italy to Germany in the 1720s. Around 1760, England became a leading producer. For the rest of the century, English instruments were the most widely known ones. In 1767, when, at a benefit at Covent Garden, Dibdin had accompanied Miss Brickler's singing 'on a new instrument called a Piano Forte',¹⁰ this instrument was obviously still a novelty. In the following year, Johann Christian Bach gave a first public recital using a Zumpe piano as a solo instrument.¹¹

England became also a large centre of music-publishing at that time, and it is only natural that editions of keyboard music play an important part among the English publications of the period. As mentioned before, publishers used one of the following title-page formulas: (1) For harpsichord; (2) For harpsichord or piano forte; (3) For piano forte. While slight deviations appear as to the exact wordings, the formulas remained substantially the same during the second half of the eighteenth century. These designations cannot be taken literally. They merely represent a convention among the publishers of the day, and, all too often, they do not express the exact intentions of the composers as regards the instrument for which a particular composition is written. Looked at in their entirety, however, trends in the use of the designations may well show a characteristic picture.

I have tried to assemble a number of such editions, large enough for an investigation by statistical methods, and, at the same time, representative of the output of such publications in England during the second half of the eighteenth century. This material is divided into two groups: Solo Music; and Ensemble and Vocal Music. The following procedure was applied:

(a) I first compiled a list of composers' names whose keyboard music was published in England between c. 1750 and c. 1800. This was done with the help of approximately fifteen rare-book dealers' catalogues. Whatever reasons the dealers had had for mentioning keyboard works by these composers, in all probability these reasons had very little to do with the title formulas. Therefore this procedure provided material which was not pre-selected, as far as the present problem is concerned.

(b) The composers' names were then checked against Barclay Squire's *Catalogue of Printed Music in the British Museum*.¹² Within the period, all British editions of solo, ensemble and vocal compositions composed by these men were included, if one or both keyboard instruments were named on the title page. I had also found a number of anonymous compositions in the dealers' catalogues and listed them as

well as similar titles given by Squire according to his method of cataloguing under the first important word of a title. Titles which were questionable for any reasons were omitted. The Solo group also includes compositions for four or six hands.

Since the publishers usually did not mention publication dates in their editions, I found it advisable to take over, without questioning their details, the estimates given by Barclay Squire in the *Catalogue*. The accuracy of this eminent scholar is well known. G. K. Fortescue, in his Preface to the *Catalogue*,¹³ mentions a lesser degree of certainty for Squire's estimates of dates of foreign publications. This statement implies the great reliability of his data as far as British publications are concerned. When the *Catalogue* was prepared, there was indeed a good deal of information available on English publishers, thanks to the research of Kidson¹⁴ and others. All this makes Squire's figures appear trustworthy. The student should, however, keep in mind that the dates of these editions are estimates and not actual data. A glance at the material reveals this quite strikingly; the years ending in 5 or 0 show an unduly large accumulation of titles as compared with the others. This evidently is due to the inclination of any appraiser to select round numbers. However, it does not falsify the results of our count (as given in Charts I and II) for we are not proceeding by single years but by groups of five or ten years. If there are any errors, it can be assumed that Squire's estimates are not far away from the correct years. In a statistical investigation based on hundreds of such editions, even a few errors can easily be borne, for they will not change the picture to any considerable extent.

CHART I TITLE WORDINGS IN ENGLISH SOLO KEYBOARD MUSIC EDITIONS

(Absolute Figures)

<i>Estimated year of publication</i>	<i>Harpsichord only</i>	<i>Both</i>	<i>Piano only</i>	<i>Total</i>
1750-1759	6	—	—	6
1760-1769	14	1	—	15
1770-1774	10	6	—	16
1775-1779	3	16	—	19
1780-1784	6	28	1	35
1785-1789	2	33	1	36
1790-1794	2	32	10	44
1795-1799	1	25	54	80
1800	—	3	35	38
Total	44	144	101	289

CHART II
TITLE WORDINGS IN ENGLISH CHAMBER AND VOCAL
MUSIC EDITIONS
(Absolute Figures)

<i>Estimated year of publication</i>	<i>Harpsichord only</i>	<i>Both</i>	<i>Piano only</i>	<i>Total</i>
1750-1759	8	—	—	8
1760-1769	27	—	—	27
1770-1774	29	3	—	32
1775-1779	7	18	1	26
1780-1784	18	20	5	43
1785-1789	11	44	6	61
1790-1794	10	32	25	67
1795-1799	5	22	48	75
1800	1	3	39	43
Total	116	142	124	382

As Charts I and II show, the count includes 671 compositions. This figure, when seen from a statistical point of view, permits a limited number of generalizations. The 671 keyboard compositions probably represent a substantial percentage of all such English publications of that time. Nearly seventy composers are represented, not counting anonymous compositions, probably an equally substantial share of those musicians who had their keyboard music published in England at that time. This study seems also to have covered a large number of the publishing houses in operation in London and sometimes in other English cities, since the list comprises approximately seventy-five publishers' designations.¹⁵

The results of this survey, as shown in Charts I and II, are somewhat top-heavy. For the period from 1750 to 1769 I find only fifty-six publications, while for the time between 1790 and 1800 (inclusive) the list comprises 347 items. This ascending trend reflects both the growth of the English publishing business and the popularization of the piano.¹⁶ Because of it, absolute figures are misleading for any comparison. In order to obtain comparable data, the figures have to be converted into percentages which express the relationship of the three title-wordings to each other during the same period (Chart III).

Comparing these percentages, the following statements may be made:

1. On the whole, the figures for Solo and Ensemble (including vocal) editions do not vary much from each other considering the fact that the small amount of material does not permit too minute an interpretation. The three columns of both groups show the same

CHART III

TITLE WORDINGS IN PERCENTAGES OF PERIOD TOTALS

<i>Estimated year of publication</i>	<i>Harpsichord only</i>		<i>Both</i>		<i>Piano only</i>	
	<i>Solo</i>	<i>Ensemble</i>	<i>Solo</i>	<i>Ensemble</i>	<i>Solo</i>	<i>Ensemble</i>
1750-1759	100	100	0	0	0	0
1760-1769	93	100	7	0	0	0
1770-1774	63	91	37	9	0	0
1775-1779	16	27	84	69	0	4
1780-1784	17	42	80	47	3	11
1785-1789	6	18	92	72	2	10
1790-1794	4	15	73	48	23	37
1795-1799	1	7	31	29	68	64
1800	0	2	8	7	92	91
Total	15	30	50	37	35	33

trends. The *Harpsichord Only* figures decline from 100% to 0% and 2% respectively in 1800, the latter figure being practically the same as 0%. The percentages for *Both Instruments* mount to climaxes of 92% and 72%, both of which occur for the period of 1785-9, and then decline to small figures of 8% and 7%, figures which can also be considered as practically the same. The percentages for *Piano Only* climb from 0% to 92% and 91%.

2. The figures express these trends in general by straight lines and without many deviations. The few irregularities which appear must be charged to the smallness of the material. This holds true in particular for the climb of the *Harpsichord Only* percentages of the Ensemble group from 27% for 1775-9 to 42% for 1780-4, which the figures show in spite of a general downward tendency. At first sight this climb appears surprising, but if one considers that we have to do with absolute figures as small as 7 and 18 respectively, it cannot be interpreted as of significance.

3. The abrupt reversal of percentages between the *Harpsichord Only* and *Both Instruments* for the years before 1770-4, and 1775-9 is remarkable. The former drop from 63% to 16% and 91% to 27% respectively, while the latter rise from 37% to 84% and 9% to 69% respectively.

4. Equally remarkable is a similar reversal when *Both Instruments* drop from 73% in 1790-4 to 31% in 1795-9 for the Solo literature, and from 72% in 1785-9 to 48% in 1790-4 for the Ensemble literature. This drop is balanced by a considerable upward movement of the *Piano Only* percentages from 23% to 68% (Solo) and from 10% to 37% (Ensemble) for the same periods.

The fact that the Solo and Ensemble figures do not vary much in their general trends is perhaps somewhat surprising in view of the

often-mentioned fact that the harpsichord stayed longer in use in ensemble music. This longer use of the older keyboard instrument, however, was probably limited to the orchestra on the concert stage.¹⁷ Chamber music, more often played in the home, was executed on the instrument available—usually the same piano on which the solo music was played. Orchestra music formed anyhow only a small part of the printed editions. As is still customary in the present, such material was probably often hand-copied. Even if orchestra music was printed, it scarcely appeared in our figures because the keyboard instrument was usually not specified; the keyboard players played as a rule from a Basso part, and such parts were not included in our material.

It may be remembered that Dibdin had advertised the piano in 1767 as 'new'. The first known English edition of printed keyboard music which mentioned the piano had, however, appeared one year earlier (Burton's *Ten Sonatas*, published by himself in 1766). According to our count it seems that, apart from Burton as publisher of his own works, the first houses to follow him were Bremner, Napier, and Welcker. Until c. 1775, they did this apparently only occasionally (possibly more or less experimentally) and not in execution of a firm policy. In the case of Bremner and Welcker, this is shown by the fact that, between 1770 and 1774, these houses together published thirty-one editions with only the harpsichord mentioned, as compared with only three editions where both instruments appear on the title page.

Parrish's observation,¹⁸ that the inclusion of the piano became general around 1775, is supported by our figures too. As a matter of fact, the sudden change in the percentages gives the impression that most publishers adapted the new wording more or less simultaneously, thus showing a reaction quite common among commercial enterprises, up to the present, where novelties are concerned. The new instrument obviously had become so popular that its inclusion into the title was generally considered as promising larger sales. This popularity can be documented by contemporary evidence too voluminous to be mentioned here. One characteristic sign may be mentioned, viz. the first appearance of a teaching method which includes the piano in its title in about 1775, the anonymous *Playing the Harpsichord, Spinett, or Piano Forte Made Easy* (Longman, Lukey & Co.).¹⁹

After having discussed the first appearance of the piano in the titles, our attention may be directed to the eventual omission of the harpsichord. The first cases of such omission appear, curiously enough, not in keyboard music proper, but in the field of vocal music. T. Giordani's *Six Canzonets, with an Accompaniment for a Piano Forte or Harp* . . . *Opera XI* (Longman, Lukey & Broderip, c. 1778) is the earliest such

edition known to me. Eleven more vocal and instrumental ensemble publications follow in the eighties, while only two editions of piano solo music can be found for the same period.

These details seem to suggest that, while the publishers had not hesitated to include the piano into the titles, they showed a somewhat greater reluctance in omitting the harpsichord, as far as solo music editions were concerned. As to ensemble and vocal music, they demonstrated greater readiness for such an omission. Publishers probably had to be somewhat more careful in vocal and instrumental chamber music in deciding how many instruments were to be included in the title. The longer the title became, the more they may have had to pay the engraver, and the more clumsy the title appeared. On the other hand, while they had to watch the number of instruments, their selection, in many cases, mattered less. The first cases of omissions (until c. 1785) were mostly vocal compositions where the keyboard instrument plays nothing but the basso continuo, as far as can be judged from the wording of the titles. Since the period did not yet demand the strict observance of a composer's original instrumentation in the manner to which musicians have become accustomed during the last century, an accompaniment marked *for piano forte or harp* probably suggested clearly enough to the sheet music buyer of the day that a harpsichord also could be used.

Just as with the inclusion of the piano, the omission of the harpsichord is for a long time limited to isolated cases. Neither composers nor publishers seem to have established firm policies for many years. Thus we find, among 118 publications of the house of Longman & Broderip (including Longman, Lukey & Broderip) between 1778 and 1794, only sixteen titles without the harpsichord. For the same period, all but seven of the thirty-one editions of music by the brothers Giuseppe and Tommaso Giordani²⁰ mention both instruments. Publications of the same publisher, or by the same composer, follow each other, using sometimes one form and sometimes the other, apparently without discrimination.

In the early nineties, about a fourth to a third of the publications leave out the harpsichord; in the second half the number increases to two-thirds; for all practical purposes the abandonment of the old instrument in the titles is complete by 1800. The general dropping of the plucked instrument shows that, when it occurred, the harpsichord had become sufficiently obsolete for publishers not to expect any more commercial benefits by appealing to players of that instrument. Indeed, the harpsichord must have disappeared somewhat earlier from the scene than is made evident through the title formula. The standard wording

including both instruments had become a stereotyped tradition during the twenty-five years of its usage, and such traditions, as a rule, change more slowly than circumstances warrant. The publishers were certainly not pioneers of the abandonment of the older instrument, but, as businessmen, merely adjusted themselves to the actual situation, after this situation had become sufficiently clear. As early as c. 1786, Thomas Busby's *A Complete Dictionary of Music, to Which is Prefixed a Familiar Introduction to the First Principles of that Science* had stated that the harpsichord's practice *has considerably declined*.²² Maybe the year of 1790 can be considered as the best approximate date for the disappearance of the harpsichord from the scene at large.

II

During the French Revolution, when a large number of noblemen and wealthy bourgeois were either killed or had to take refuge outside of France, the persecutions were accompanied by confiscations of property. The eleventh sub-commission of a *Commission temporaire des arts*²³ had to inventory those of the confiscated ancient and foreign instruments which were *les plus rares, par leur perfection*.²⁴ Two musicians served on that body; Antonio Bartolomeo Bruni (1759–1823), composer of operas and string instrument methods, and Bernard Sarette (1765–1858), co-organizer and later first director of the *Conservatoire National*.²⁵ One of the main purposes of this surveying was to provide that institution with a collection of instruments which were to *serve as models because of their working principles*.²⁶ This curious attitude was obviously based on the Encyclopaedists' belief that the progress of instrumental music depended on the advance of manufacture.²⁷ While scarcely any of the instruments reached the Conservatoire collection,²⁸ a good deal of the *Inventaire* was accomplished.²⁹

CHART IV HARPSICHORDS* (according to Bruni).

No.	Description	House where confiscated†	Was there a piano in the same house
5	A harpsichord painted green (<i>fond vert</i>) with gilded stripes, without key	Marquis de la Salle	yes
6	A spinet, triangular shape, very bad	id.	yes
26	A harpsichord, gilded with arabesques, by Andreas Ruckers. <i>Me fecit Antwerpen (!)</i>	Pignatelli	yes
33	A harpsichord, painted white, with gilded and carved legs, rebuilt by Pascal Taskin, year 1778	Kinsky	yes

CHART IV—*continued*

No.	Description	House where confiscated†	<i>Was there a piano in the same house</i>
34	A harpsichord, painted grey with gilded stripes, rebuilt in Paris by Pascal Taskin, year 1778	Kinsky	yes
41	A harpsichord of ordinary wood	Cosse-Brissac	yes
47	A harpsichord, gilded and painted with arabesques, without name	Montmorency	yes
55	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, built by Andreas Ruckers: <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i> , year 1638	Croy d'Havre	no
71	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, by Andreas Ruckers. <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i> , year 1616	Lauragnais	no
72	A harpsichord, painted red and its legs gilded, without name	Orsay	yes
76	A green harpsichord with gilded stripes, without key	la Force	yes
77	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded flowers, by Joannes (!) Ruckers: <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i>	Voisins	no
78	A harpsichord by Hans Ruckers, painted black with gilded flowers and carved legs, year 1606	Noailles-	no
80	A spinet, year 1726	Mouchy	no
81	A harpsichord, painted green with gilded stripes, without maker's name	id.	no
82	A harpsichord painted green with gilded stripes, provided with <i>ravallément</i> ‡ by Pascal Taskin, year 1776	Thiroux de Mondésir	no
83	A harpsichord painted green, with gilded stripes, with broken legs, repaired (<i>raccomodé</i>) by Nadreau and built by Pascal Taskin, year 1774	Laborde	no
92	A harpsichord, walnut, by Jean Henri Silbermann, year 1769, at Strasbourg	id.	no
93	A harpsichord, mahogany, superb, gilded stripe and gilded and carved legs,‡ without maker's name and without music stand	Maubec	no
94	A small harpsichord to be placed underneath§	Amboise	no
95	A grey harpsichord, without maker's name	id.	no
96	A grey harpsichord, by Antoine Valter, year 1725	Selle	no
98	A harpsichord, painted green with gilded stripes, year 1645	Roux	no
113	A black harpsichord, with gilded stripes, by Pascal Taskin, pupil of Blanckett, from (<i>en</i>) 1770, n° 15	Surgères	no
		Menus-Plaisirs	yes

CHART IV—continued

No.	Description	House where confiscated†	Was there a piano in the same house
114	A harpsichord, painted with a flower design, provided with <i>ravalement</i> , by Pascal Taskin, from 1774	Menus-Plaisirs	yes
115	A harpsichord, painted yellow, with figures, without legs, by Joannes Ruckers, <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i> , n° 1	id.	yes
116	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, built by Antoine Valter, from 1724	id.	yes
117	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, and flowers, without name, marked n° 29	id.	yes
118	A spinet, painted black with golden stripes, without name	id.	yes
122	A painted and gilded harpsichord, by Hans Ruckers, <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i> , provided with <i>ravalement</i> by Pascal Tasquin (!), at Paris, from 1771	Bacquencourt	no
124	A harpsichord, painted grey with gilded stripes, built by Joseph Treyer, known as (<i>surnommé</i>) Lempereur, at Paris, 1770, estimated 200 francs	La Chapelle	no
126	A painted and gilded harpsichord, without maker's name	Bouthillier	yes
130	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, by Johannes Ruckers: <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i>	Xavier	yes
131	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, without name	id.	yes
134	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, by Antonius Valter, <i>Lutetiae Parisiorum</i> , year 1755	Grimm	yes
151	An English harpsichord by Thoaner, year 1772, estimated 2,000 francs	Ambassadeur d'Espagne	yes
154	An English harpsichord, mahogany, perfectly new, built by Johannes Broadwood (!) <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1789, estimated 2,000 francs	Chartres	no
155	A harpsichord, painted red with gilded and carved legs, without name, coming from Noailles, estimated 400 francs	Saint-Priest	yes
156	A harpsichord, painted yellow with flowers, built by François Blanchet in 1749, without legs, coming from St James, estimated 90 francs	id.	yes
160	A harpsichord, painted green with gilded stripes, without name, estimated 250 francs	Lostanges	no
166	A painted harpsichord, rebuilt by Baltazard Peronard, year 1777, estimated 500 francs	Durney	no

CHART IV—*continued*

No.	Description	House where confiscated†	<i>Was there a piano in the same house</i>
174	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, without name	Breteuil	no
175	A very beautiful harpsichord, by Joannes (!) Ruckers, <i>Me fecit Antverpiae</i> , year 1637	Fitche	no
186	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, without name, estimated 300 francs	Luzerne	no
208	A harpsichord, painted green with gilded stripes, without name, marked n° 1630	Mirecourt	no
211	A harpsichord, painted black with gilded stripes, built by Henri Hemsch, in Paris, year 1763, estimated 300 francs	Vente	no
221	A harpsichord, painted grey with gilded stripes, without maker's name, estimated 150 francs	Vilquier	yes
225	A harpsichord, painted yellow with gilded stripes, without maker's name, marked 1621 estimated 400 francs	Marbeuf	yes
274	A harpsichord, without name, painted grey, with gilded fillets, estimated 200 francs	Thuisy	no
281	A spinet with <i>grand ravalement</i> ,‡ painted black and with golden fillets, estimated 250 francs	Thelis	no
284	A harpsichord in bad state, painted black, without name, coming from the condemned Vallot (?)	id.	no
285	A harpsichord, painted grey, formed like a box, ** built by Baillon, front board is missing, estimated 60 francs	Jaucourt	no
289	A harpsichord of walnut wood, without name, estimated 300 francs	Havrincourt	no
306	A harpsichord by Ruckers, painted <i>merd'oye</i> with gilded fillets, estimated 600 francs	Pressigny	no
310	A harpsichord, painted black, without name	Jerningham	no
314	A harpsichord built by Henri Hemsch, 1763	Lowendal	no
323	A harpsichord by Henri Hemsch, painted red, estimated 800 francs	Croy	yes
325	A harpsichord by Joannes Germain, painted grey with gilded stripe, estimated 400 francs	Lezay	no
337	A harpsichord by Henry Hemsch, painted red, estimated 400 francs	Oppède	no
343	A spinet, painted black, without maker's name, estimated 60 francs	id.	no
345	A harpsichord, painted grey with golden stripe, built by Baltazard Peronard in 1760, belonging to the <i>émigré</i> la Mark, estimated 600 francs	La Marck	no

CHART IV—continued

No.	Description	House where confiscated†	Was there a piano in the same house
346	A bad harpsichord by Ruckers, painted black with golden stripe, having all its legs broken, belonging to the <i>émigré</i> Durfort, estimated 200 francs	Durfort	no

* Incl. spinets. The original spelling of names and quotations has been left unchanged.

† See Gallay, *op. cit.*, for details of identification.

‡ *Ravalement*: change made in the eighteenth century on older instruments by completion of the lowest, 'short' octave. *Grand ravalement* refers to instruments with a range of five complete, or nearly complete, octaves. Georg Kinsky, *Musikhistorisches Museum von Wilhelm Heyer in Köln: Katalog* (Cologne, Wilhelm Heyer, 1910), 99, footnote 1.

§ *Bande et pieds dorés et sculptés*.

|| *Pour mettre dessous*; the meaning is not clear.

** *Cassette*.

CHART V
PIANOS
(according to Bruni)

No.	Description	House where confiscated
1	A German piano* by Henrion, year 1784	Marquis Caillebot de la Salle
2	A piano by Schoene, year 1788	id.
3	A piano, without name, with white and black rays	id.
4	A piano, without key	id.
19	A piano by Johannes Zumpe, <i>Londini</i> , year 1787	Cogolin
22	A piano de Johann Boffried, rue des Petits-Carreaux, n° 5 . . . ? , year 1790	Perpigna[n]
27	A small piano with pedal, table shaped. †	Pignatelli
30	An English piano, by <i>Schoene and successors</i> to ‡ , year 1788	Kinsky
31	An English piano, year 1788	id.
32	A piano, <i>organisé</i> , § painted white, by Adam Berjer (!), <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1788	id.
35	An English piano by Johann Zumpe, year 1744	Vintimille
36	An English piano by Schoene, year 1786	id.
40	A piano with drawer, superb, without name	Cosse-Brissac
48	A piano by Erard <i>frères</i> , Paris, year 1788	Montmorency
56	An English piano by Schoene, year 1788, and surrendered to the citizen Sarette by order of the <i>Comité du salut public</i>	Tavernier de Boulogne
57	An English piano, <i>organisé</i> by Longuian (!) and Broderip, n° 26	id.
63	A piano by Sebastianus Erard, year 1787	id.
68	A piano, <i>organisé</i> , by Sebastien Erard <i>et frères</i> , year 1790	Beccdelièvre
69	A piano without key	id.
73	A piano, <i>organisé</i> , by Johannes Zumpe, <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1771	Orsay
75	A piano by Schoene, year 1784	la Force
97	A piano in mahogany, without maker's name, coming from the <i>Maison de la Révolution</i>	Englien
99	A piano by Fredericus Beck, year 1779	Brignard
105	A piano by Johannes Pohlman, year 1772	Duvaucel
106	A piano by Fredericus Beck, <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1779, estimated 600 francs	Maison Egalité
107	A piano by Zimmermann, built in Paris in 1786, estimated 400 francs	Lavoisier
111	A piano by Fredericus Beck, year 1774	Menus-Plaisirs du Roi
112	A piano, without name, marked n° 37	id.
120	A piano by Schoene, 1787	Boutin
125	A piano by Schoene, year 1785	Castries

CHART V—continued

No.	Description	House where confiscated
127	A piano, by Erard frères, year 1789	Bouthillier
132	A piano by Joannes Zimmermann, <i>fecit</i> in 1780	Xavier
135	A piano by Johannes Pohlman, year 1771	Grimm
138	An English piano by Johannes Zumpe, from 1769	Gougenot
141	An English piano by Schoene, <i>successor</i> † of Johannes Zumpe, <i>Londini fecerunt</i> , estimated 800 francs	Kerry
148	A piano by Sebastien Erard, year 1786, estimated 600 francs	Ambassadeur d'Espagne
150	A piano, <i>organisé</i> , by Adam Berger, <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1775, estimated 1,200 francs	id.
159	A piano by Christopher Qanter, <i>Londini fecit</i> , year 1784, estimated 720 francs	Saint-Priest
173	A piano by Korwer, year 1783, estimated 300 francs	Ecquevilly
177	A piano, built by Dambalt at Courbevoye in 1784, at the (aux; possibly meaning <i>from the</i>) <i>Gardes-Suisses du Roi</i>	Daix
178	A piano by Joannes Pohlman, <i>Londini</i> , year 1773	Gontaut-Biron
179	A second piano, built by Baltazard Peronard in Paris, year 1771	id.
191	A piano Pilhelm, freudenthaler (!), built in Paris, 1789, estimated 500 francs	Sainte-Amaranthe
202	A piano by Sebastien Erard, Paris, 1785, estimated 800 francs	Choiseul-Gouffier
207	A piano by Fredericus Beck, estimated 1,500 francs	Argenteuil
219	A piano, <i>organisé</i> , by Sebastien Erard frère et Cie, built in Paris, 1791, estimated 2,000 francs	Vilquier
220	Another piano which cannot be opened at all without key, estimated 700 francs	id.
222	A piano by Schoene, built in 1786, estimated 1,000 francs	Mayet
224	A piano by Johannes Pohlmann, <i>Londini fecit</i> 1776; the paintings on the cover are damaged; estimated 800 francs	Marbeuf
228	A piano by Erard, built at Paris in 1787, estimated 600 francs	Coquet
237	A piano by Sebastien Erard, built in Paris, 1784, rue Bourbon, <i>faubourg</i> St Germain, n° 109, said [belonging]** to the condemned [women] Levi, wife of Bérenger, found in the apartment which she occupied with the condemned [women] Marbeuf, estimated 800 francs	Bérenger

CHART V—continued

No.	Description	House where confiscated
250	A piano, without maker's name	Marquise de la Salle
293	A piano by Zumpe, 1783, estimated 1,500 francs	Comte de Montmorency
307	A piano by Zumpe, 1784	Vaupalière
308	A grand piano from Regensburg (Ratisbonne) belonging to Laugeron	id.
309	A small piano by Zumpe, belonging to the same	id.
312	A piano, without maker's name	Jebert
313	A piano of oak wood, without maker's name	Talleyrand-Périgord
322	A piano by Beck, built in 1788, belonging to Debrange, <i>émigré</i> , rue de Sevres, estimated 5,000 francs	Croy
324	A piano of walnut wood, without maker's name, estimated 600 francs	id.
356	A piano by Erard, built in 1787, estimated 8,000 francs	Doria
360	A piano by Erard, built in 1784	Goulet
361	A piano, without maker's name, of black wood	id.
367	A piano by Erard, built in 1789	Dongé

* The term *forte-piano* is used everywhere, except for nos. 27, 138, 308, 309 (*piano*). See also Chart VI, footnote 1.

† As the words *en forme de table* appear nowhere else, it is unlikely that they here describe an ordinary square-shaped instrument. They probably refer to one of those combinations of furniture and music instrument found frequently in collections. (Compare Kinsky, *op. cit.*, nos. 125, 130, 131, 134, 138, 139.)

‡ Quoted in English.

§ With a built-in organ stop.

|| *Qui n'est point ouvert*.

★★ *Soit disant à la condamnée Levi, femme Béranger*.

Charts IV and V show respectively the harpsichords (or spinets) and the pianos listed in this inventory. The entries do not reveal technical details or describe the quality of the sound produced. Often thumb-nail descriptions of the exterior decoration, makers' names and dates and sometimes appraisals appear. Gallay questions somewhat Bruni's taxations, because the latter appraises string instruments of unknown French makers relatively high in proportion to Italian instruments,³⁰ but this objection, even if justified, does not concern his descriptions, and probably not his estimates, of keyed instruments. On the whole, Bruni's descriptions, dry and laconic as they are, seem trustworthy as far as they go. Each of the two musicians could certainly distinguish between harpsichords and pianos. No reason can be seen why makers'

names and the dates should not have been listed substantially correctly, nor do the estimates seem fantastic, at least as far as one can judge these appraisals—given in a time of political and financial turmoil—from our present-day point of view. The inventory comprises sixty-two harpsichords (including five spinets) and sixty-four pianos (including six instruments qualified as *organisés*). Thus, approximately 50% of the instruments taken from the highest strata of French society were still harpsichords at such a late date.

At first glance, this seems to indicate a much greater use of the plucked instrument than in contemporary London. If there had still been as many plucked instruments in use in England, the British publishers would hardly have suppressed the word 'harpsichord' in the titles. The figures seem to support a certain conservative attitude of the French towards the piano which has been mentioned before by some writers. If there existed such a conservatism, it can be found in certain often-quoted statements by famous men such as Voltaire and Balbâtre, and in the fact that piano manufacture started in France later than in England or Germany (1770).³¹ Students, however, should be warned not to interpret this reluctance towards the piano in too general a manner. The Parisians became acquainted with the piano possibly earlier than the English, in 1759.³² The first French edition mentioning the piano on the title is Nicolas Sejan's *Ariettes choisies mises en Sonates, pour le clavecin ou le piano-forte*. It dates from 1765,³³ one year before 'both instruments' appears on an English edition. The first concert took place in 1768,³⁴ in the same year as in London.

CHART VI DATED HARPSICHORDS

		Percentages
Before 1700	14*	42.5
1700-1749	4	12
1750-1779	14†	42.5
after 1779	1	3
Total	33	100

DETAILS 1750-1779

1750-1759	1	7
1760-1769	4	29
1770-1779	9†	64
Total	14	100

* One instrument rebuilt in 1771 is included.

† Including five instruments where the dates refer to rebuilding or *ravalement*, or where it is not certain whether it refers to the making or to rebuilding.

At closer scrutiny, even the equal proportion of harpsichords to pianos, as shown by the *Inventaire*, does not prove to be representative for the actual use of the plucked instruments. Twenty-five of the latter, more than 40%, were confiscated in houses in which pianos were also found (Chart VI). It is very doubtful in these cases whether the harpsichords were still being played to any extent. Probably nobody in an aristocratic household of the period thought of immediately discarding an old instrument when a new one arrived. In particular it was hardly customary to sell it; the financial return did not interest the wealthy owners. In some places it may have still been used, even if a piano was available, e.g. as a continuo instrument with an orchestra-like group. In most cases, however, one can assume the harpsichord was merely moved from the living quarters or from the *salons* to some other place in the vast mansions, frequently without ever being touched again.³⁴

Still more argument for an early recognition of the piano can be found if one counts only those keyboard instruments which are dated, or datable.³² All such harpsichords (Chart VI), except one, date from before 1780. The only exception, No. 154, is a Broadwood from 1789, highly valued, from the possession of the Duc de Chatres. 45.5% of our dated instruments are dated from 1750 or later, among them 30% from 1770 or later.³⁶

CHART VII DATED PIANOS

		Percentages
Before 1770	1	2
1770-1779	11	24
1780-1784	9	20
1785-1789	22	48
after 1789	3	6
	—	—
Total	46	100

DETAILS 1769-1791

1769	1	1776	1	1785	2
1770	0	1777-8	0	1786	4
1771	3	1779	2	1787	6
1772	1	1780	1	1788	7
1773	1	1781-2	0	1789	3
1774	2	1783	2	1790	2
1775	1	1784	6	1791	1

The earliest piano (Chart VII) is dated 1769; 74% of them were made in 1780 or later. Although, as shown above, there were at the time of the Revolution still as many harpsichords as pianos, the taste of French society must have changed to the new instrument already around 1780.

NOTES

- ¹ See any of the standard histories of music.
- ² Rosamond E. M. Harding, *The Piano-Forte: Its History traced to the Great Exhibition of 1851* (Cambridge: University Press, 1933), 81ff.
- ³ Carl George Parrish, *The Early Piano and Its Influence on Keyboard Technique and Composition in the Eighteenth Century* (Harvard Dissertation, 1939). Many of the quotations from Parrish's work can also be found in his 'Criticisms of the Piano when it was New', *MQ*, XXX (1944), 428ff.
- ⁴ A. Bruni, *Un Inventaire sous la Terreur: Etat des Instruments de Musique Relevé chez les Emigrés et Condamnés par A. Bruni, L'un des Delegates de la Convention*. Introduction, notices biographiques et notes par J. Gallay (Paris: Georges Chamerot, 1890).
- ⁵ Harding, *op. cit.*, 5ff.
- ⁶ According to Agricola (David, H. T. & A. Mendel, *The Bach-Reader* [New York, Norton, 1945], 254).
- ⁷ Johann Joachim Quantz, *Versuch einer Anweisung die Floete traversiere zu spielen: Kritisch revidierter Neudruck nach dem Original*, Berlin (Johann Friedrich Voss), 1752, ed. Arnold Schering (Leipzig: Kahnt, 1906), 175.
- ⁸ Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach, *Essay on the True Art of Playing Keyboard Instruments*, trans. and ed. William J. Mitchell (New York: Norton & Co., 1949), 36.
- ⁹ *Ibid.*, 172.
- ¹⁰ Charles Sanford Terry, *John Christian Bach* (London: Oxford University Press, 1929), 113.
- ¹¹ *Ibid.*
- ¹² (2 vols., London [etc.], British Museum [etc.], 1912.)
- ¹³ *Ibid.*, I, iii.
- ¹⁴ Frank Kidson, *British Music Publishers, Printers and Engravers* [etc.], (London: Hill & Sons, 1900).
- ¹⁵ Actually, however, the number of publishing houses is smaller as certain firms changed their style in the course of time. Not included in this figure are the cases where 'Author' or 'Editor' s given as publisher's designation.
- ¹⁶ There were forty-five different piano manufacturing firms in London before 1800. The house of Broadwood alone made 6,000 square and 1,000 grand pianos between 1780 and 1800. (Parrish, *op. cit.*, 42.)
- ¹⁷ For the performance of symphonies, Haydn still used a Shudi and Broadwood harpsichord during the last years of his life, while resorting to the piano for other purposes. (Karl Geiringer, *Haydn. A Creative Life in Music* [New York: Norton & Co., 1946], 192).
- ¹⁸ Parrish, *op. cit.*, 203ff.
- ¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 208.
- ²⁰ The compositions of the two brothers cannot always clearly be separated. Those which mention the piano only are all ensemble works. Four of them use the designation *piano forte* or *harp*.
- ²¹ Parrish, *op. cit.*, 38.
- ²² Quoted by Parrish, *op. cit.*, 65-66.
- ²³ Decrees of August 14, October 13 and 19, 1792, and of *Floréal* 13th, year II.—Bruni, IXff.
- ²⁴ *Ibid.*, XVI.
- ²⁵ Robert Eitner, *Bio-bibliographisches Quellen-Lexikon der Musiker und*

Musikgelehrten [etc.], (Leipzig: Breitkopf & Haertel, 1900-4, repr. New York: Musurgia, 1947), II, 219 & VIII, 426.—The Conservatory's original designation was *Institut National de Musique*.

²⁶ Bruni, XXXI.

²⁷ Alfred Richard Oliver, *The Encyclopedists as Critics of Music* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1947), 69.

²⁸ Closson (*History of the Piano*, trans. D. Ames [London: Paul Elek, 1947], 74) reports that they were burnt as fire-wood during the cold winter of 1816. The present Conservatoire collection was assembled later.

²⁹ Between *Floréal* 13th, II, and *Thermidor* 29th, III (May 2, 1794 to August 16, 1795)—For complete title, see Bruni, XXXV. Sarette's name is not mentioned in the document; his share in the work is unknown.

³⁰ Bruni, XVI.

³¹ 1770 (Closson, 97).

³² *Ibid.* (quoting de Bricqueville, *Le Clavecin de Madame Du Barry et le Piano de la Reine Marie Antoinette* [Paris: 1892].

³³ Parrish, 45.

³⁴ Closson, 97.

^{34a} A certain illustration for this attitude can be found in Forkel's remark of 1802 on the fifteen Silbermann pianos collected by Frederick the Great approximately fifty years earlier (instruments which must have been as obsolete as harpsichords by that time): 'I hear that they all now stand, unfit for use, in various corners of the Royal Palace' (David-Mendel, *op. cit.*, 305⁸).

³⁵ Being interested in the *latest* use of the harpsichord, we included also *mise en ravalement* dates.

³⁶ As to the older instruments, attention has been drawn to the large number of seventeenth-century instruments, mostly built by members of the Ruckers family in Antwerp. (Curt Sachs, *The History of Musical Instruments* [New York: Norton & Co., 1940], 375.) Evidently these instruments were regarded as antiques of value, otherwise there would not have survived so many more harpsichords from that period than e.g. from 1700 to 1750.